

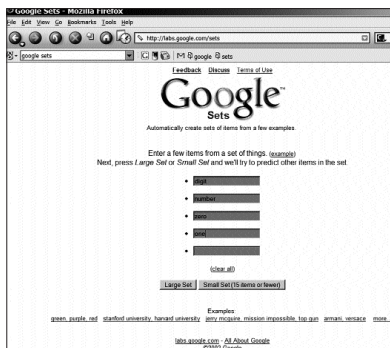
4.6 Google Sets

(<http://labs.google.com/sets>)

This one might seem like a toy at first. In fact, most people on the forum for this Lab product do seem to use it like a toy—a pastime, something mildly addictive. Here's how it works.

You get five empty boxes, of which you fill in two or more. These should be related—for example, fruits, such as “apple,” “banana,” and so on. When you click “Large Set” or “Small Set,” you’ll get related items. So, for example, if you fill in two fruits, you get a lot of fruit names when you click the button.

It's not very intelligent: for example, one user on the forum complained that he typed in names of various rotund objects—“ball,” “apple,” and so on, and that Google Sets didn't return more round objects. So don't expect such things to happen!



Here are a few sample Searches we did:

- We used “Bhutan,” “India,” and “Sri Lanka,” and got the names of other South Asian countries.
- “Preity Zinta,” “Madhuri Dixit,” and “Shilpa Shetty” produced lots of other Indian actresses, but interspersed in the results were “myself,” “a lioness,” and “Bill Gates”! But we must note the intelligence here: apart from the above three, the results were all *actresses*—no actors!
- For the Large Set option, we used the names of five classical composers, and got a set of a large number of composers—but amongst the set was the word “introduction”!

So what use can Google sets be, beyond the fun and games? Here are a few scenarios (where you probably can't use regular search for finding what you're looking for, or where Google Sets is more likely to come up with an answer faster:

- You've forgotten most high-school maths, and you're wondering what the other trig terms are besides sin, cos and tan. So you type in “sine,” “cosine,” and “tangent,” and voila—you get “secant” and “cosecant,” along with a lot of other maths terms.
- You could use it as a thesaurus of sorts. Key in “bright,” “cheerful,” and “happy,” and you get “delighted,” “joyful,” and so on. You wouldn't be able to Google this, but there's always the thesaurus to help you out in situations like this. Still, Sets has an edge over the thesaurus, we think, because it gives you ideas. “Delighted” is *related* to our three terms, and the thesaurus probably won't give you this.
- Your friends are presenting college seminars on *Probability Theory*, *Set Theory*, and *Operations Research*. You're looking for a topic. Let Sets help you—check it out!

4.7 Google Trends

(www.google.com/trends)

“See what the world is searching for,” the tagline goes. This one is simple: enter in a search phrase, and you'll get:

Search Volume: A graph that goes along a timeline, which shows you when the phrase or word was searched for and how much. Data is available for three years.

News Reference Volume: A little graph underneath the main graph, which tells you how often your search phrase appeared in the news, according to time. Again, data is available for three years.

News Pointers: When there's a surge in the news for a particular term (the term you typed in), Google Trends marks the point in time